

Wednesday's ideas. Today's possibilities.

Composition and depth lead into editing, pacing and montage. This guide is optional and ungraded. You do not need to have used it before Monday's class.

1 • Notice

Look at the first scene. Where does your eye land? You can point, speak, type, or simply look.

2 • Try one change

Choose Quiet scene, then Bright doorway. The doorway becomes lighter against its wall. That is a change in contrast. Did your attention move? A different viewer may notice something else.

3 • Carry the question forward

Wednesday: what happens inside a frame? Monday: what happens between frames, and how much time do we have to look?

Keep this for later

No need to finish the whole recap now. Use the illustrated PDF offline, or the web experiments when you want to try another idea. Videos and outside links still require internet. The class spends five minutes introducing the recap, then moves on.

A reliable start

Watch the classroom screen, share a device, or use your own. No account, grade, leaderboard, or private answer submission. Optional browser notes do not sync between devices.

Next: the six visual lessons and their practice choices.

A VISUAL FIELD GUIDE

Make it read.

**You already notice things.
Now explore how images help you notice.**



One place. Many choices.

Try a different emphasis, path, gap, placement, focus, or view. Notice what changed. Change your mind as often as you like.

NO SCORE. NO SUBMISSION. NO PRESSURE.

Support for the September 9, 2026 Composition & Depth topic. This guide includes helper vocabulary and optional examples. It does not claim that every activity happened in class.

01 / COMPOSITION + ATTENTION

Give the eye a place to begin.

A frame can contain many things. Your choices help a viewer decide what to notice first, next, and after that.



A quieter doorway.



A brighter doorway. Same position.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Frame

The visible area of an image. Its edges decide what we can and cannot see.

Composition

How visual elements are arranged inside the frame.

Focal point

The person, object, or area that draws attention.

Visual hierarchy

The order of attention among elements. Size, contrast, position, focus, and movement can contribute.

Contrast

A noticeable difference: light against dark, large against small, or still against moving.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

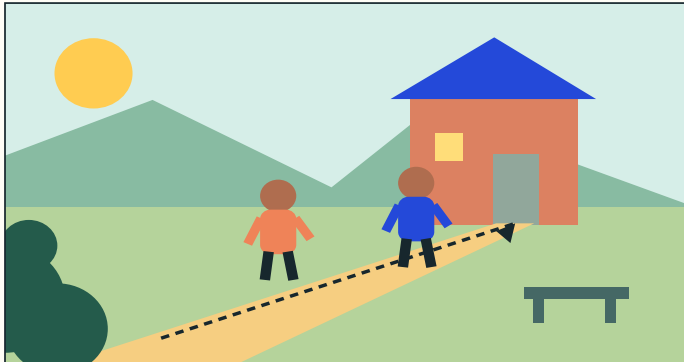
Biggest does not always mean first. A small bright doorway can stand out against larger, quieter shapes.

Bring it to a game. In a game, hierarchy can help a player find a meeting place, notice a partner, or read an important object. Test that prediction with another viewer.

02 / LEADING LINES

Make a route for attention.

Edges, paths, gestures, and repeated shapes can suggest where to look. A line does useful work when you can explain what it leads toward.



The path leads toward the door.



The path leads toward the friend.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Leading lines

Visible or implied lines that guide attention through a frame.

Implied line

A direction suggested without a continuous drawn line, such as a person's gaze or a row of objects.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Not every line is a leading line. A decorative stripe may divide the image without guiding you to something meaningful.

Bring it to a game. Paths and environmental edges can suggest where a player could go. They do not guarantee the route is accessible or that every player will follow it.

03 / NEGATIVE SPACE + RELATIONSHIPS

Let the space say something.

The area around and between subjects is part of the composition. Changing a gap can change a possible reading, even when the people stay the same.



A smaller gap between people.



A wider gap. What could it suggest?

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Negative space

The less occupied area around and between subjects. It does not have to be blank or white.

Positive space

The area occupied by the main subjects or forms.

Spatial relationship

How things relate through distance, position, direction, and overlap.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

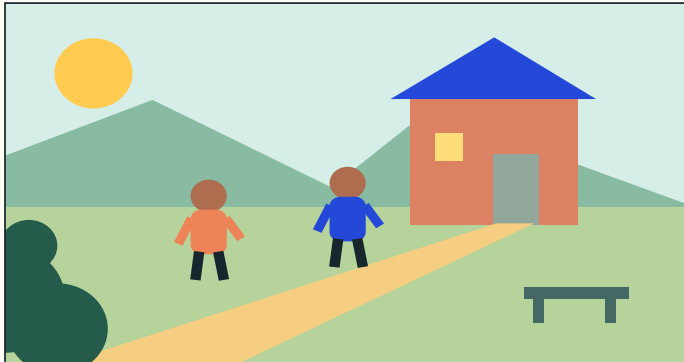
Lots of space does not automatically mean loneliness. It could suggest freedom, scale, safety, anticipation, or separation, depending on context.

Bring it to a game. For a game about people needing each other, spacing might show an invitation to gather, a barrier to cross, or a person waiting for help.

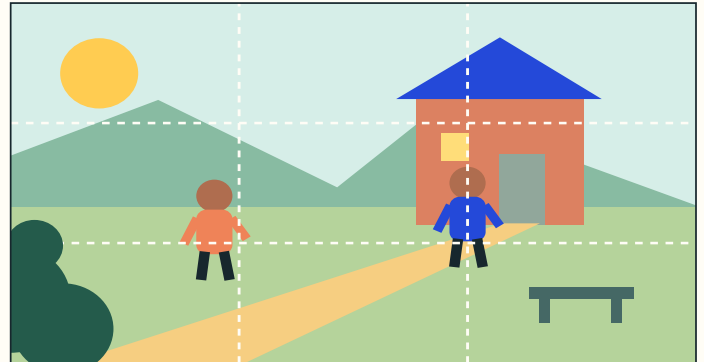
04 / THIRDS + BALANCE

A useful grid. Not a rulebook.

A three-by-three grid gives you positions to try. Centering a subject is also a choice. Ask what a placement communicates, not whether it earns a geometry score.



Center is a possible choice.



Thirds generate another possibility.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Rule of thirds

A composition guide with two equally spaced vertical and two horizontal lines. You can test subjects near those lines or intersections.

Symmetry

A matching arrangement of shapes or positions on either side of an imaginary line, like a mirror relationship.

Visual balance

How attention feels distributed across an image. An image can feel balanced with matching sides or different shapes that hold attention together.

Visual weight

How strongly an element attracts attention through its size, contrast, or how crowded it is.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

An off-center image is not automatically better. Symmetry can communicate stability, ritual, tension, or emphasis when the context supports it.

Bring it to a game. Use a grid as a way to generate alternatives. Then check the actual scene, screen size, and player task.

05 / DEPTH + DEPTH OF FIELD

Where it is ≠ how sharp it is.

These two ideas are related, but they answer different questions. Spatial layers describe position. Depth of field describes the range of distances that appears sharp.



Positions: near, middle, far.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Foreground

The part of the represented scene closest to the viewpoint.

Middle ground

The part between the foreground and background.

Background

The part of the represented scene farthest from the viewpoint.

Depth

The sense of near and far. Overlap, size differences, and lines that converge into the distance can suggest depth in a flat image.

SAME OBJECT POSITIONS



Focus: which distances read sharply?

Depth of field

The range of distances that appears acceptably sharp.

Shallow depth of field

A relatively narrow range of distances appears sharp; other distances look softer.

Deep depth of field / deep focus

A relatively broad range of distances appears sharp.

Focus

In this context, image sharpness at a selected distance. Attention and optical focus are not the same thing.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Blurring the background does not move it closer or farther away. A flat image can suggest depth even when everything is sharp.

Bring it to a game. An engine's camera can keep a partner sharp and soften the surroundings, or preserve several distances so the player can read the environment. Choose for the information the player needs.

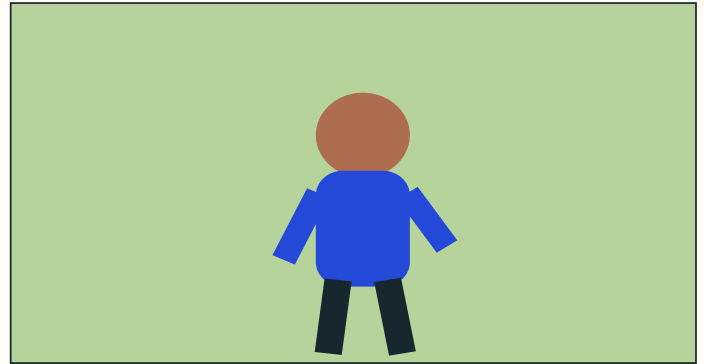
06 / ESTABLISHING + FOCAL ISOLATION

Help us know where we are.

A view can tell us where a scene happens and how its parts connect. Another view can emphasize one person while leaving less context visible.



More setting and spatial relationships.



A closer view, with less setting.

WORDS THAT HELP YOU DESCRIBE IT

Establishing shot

A shot that orients the viewer to a setting or to important spatial relationships. It is often wide, but its purpose defines it.

Wide shot

A view that shows a relatively large area around its subject. This describes the view's scale, not necessarily its function.

Framing

Choosing what appears inside the frame and how the edges contain or exclude it.

Blue Lock (visual)

Our course shorthand for making a focal character or object stand out through color, light, or position. It is an example of hierarchy, not a standard cinematography term.

A USEFUL DISTINCTION

Wide and establishing are not synonyms. A wide view may fail to orient us; several closer views can sometimes establish a space.

Bring it to a game. Show a bridge, a partner, and a destination together when players need to understand their relationship. Isolate a character when their action matters most, while testing what context is lost.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

Choose a plausible approach. Predict its effect before reading the explanation. No score or submission; changing your mind is part of learning.

01 / COMPOSITION + ATTENTION

You want the doorway to be noticed. Compare these attention choices.

- A. Keep the scene quiet.** The doorway competes quietly with the other shapes. Where did you look first? Keep this as your comparison.
- B. Brighten the doorway.** The doorway is lighter against its wall. Compare your first look with the quiet scene; this changes contrast, not position.
- C. Highlight the friend instead.** The blue friend gains emphasis. This is a useful competing design: when might noticing a partner matter more than noticing the exit?

TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Predict where a viewer will look first. Use the attention controls, then name one visible change that supports or challenges your prediction.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

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02 / LEADING LINES

You want two players to find a meeting point. Try a route.

A. Point the path toward the doorway. The path edges lead toward the doorway. That gives the route a destination; it does not prove every player will follow it.

B. Point the path toward the friend. The route ends near the friend. Compare what it asks a new player to notice, without moving the people.

C. Show a guide over the doorway route. The dashed line describes one possible eye route. It is an explanatory overlay, not a record of where someone actually looked.

TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Try both path directions. Trace the line with your finger, name its destination, and explain one reason to keep either version.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

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03 / NEGATIVE SPACE + RELATIONSHIPS

Two people meet. Which spacing serves the moment you imagine?

A. Bring them closer. The gap is small. It might suggest intimacy, crowding, or urgency. Which reading fits the story you would give this scene?

B. Leave some room between them. The gap leaves room for both figures. What can they do in that space? Compare with the closer version.

C. Move them farther apart. The larger gap can suggest distance or room to approach. What information would you need before calling it loneliness?

TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Move the gap once. Describe the space, offer a reading, then give a second reading that could also fit. What added detail would help distinguish them?

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

Choose a plausible approach. Predict its effect before reading the explanation. No score or submission; changing your mind is part of learning.

04 / THIRDS + BALANCE

Make the blue friend important. Compare placement choices.

A. Center the friend. The friend is centered. That can establish emphasis or symmetry. Centering is a usable choice, not an error.

B. Place the friend near a third. The friend moves toward the right third, opening space on the left. What might that space be for?

C. Show the thirds grid over that placement. The grid shows a compositional guide. Turning it on does not itself make the composition better; compare the frame with the grid hidden.

TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Compare center and thirds with the grid hidden. Pick a version for this goal and point to one tradeoff. Now try the other version for a different goal.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

Choose a plausible approach. Predict its effect before reading the explanation. No score or submission; changing your mind is part of learning.

05 / DEPTH + DEPTH OF FIELD

The viewer can inspect one sharp layer. Which layer matters for your scene?

- A. Keep the near plant sharp.** The foreground plant stays sharp. The friends and house soften; their positions do not change. What might the plant conceal or suggest?
- B. Keep the friends sharp.** The middle-ground friends stay sharp. The near and far layers soften. This directs attention through sharpness, not movement.
- C. Keep the far house sharp.** The background house stays sharp. Near objects still occupy the foreground even when soft. Position and focus are different.

TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Switch the sharp layer from friends to plant. Name which layer is nearest before and after, then describe which layer draws your eye. Keep position and attention separate.

THINK, THEN PEEK

A little practice. A lot of permission.

Choose a plausible approach. Predict its effect before reading the explanation. No score or submission; changing your mind is part of learning.

06 / ESTABLISHING + FOCAL ISOLATION

Introduce the meeting place. What does each view reveal or withhold?

- A. Show the place and the route.** The wider view shows people, route and destination together. It reveals geography while making the face smaller.
- B. Frame the friend more closely.** The closer framing gives the friend more room in the image and hides part of the setting. What becomes harder to know?
- C. Keep the frame; isolate with light.** The frame stays wide while light and reduced competing emphasis isolate the friend. This changes attention without a closer crop.

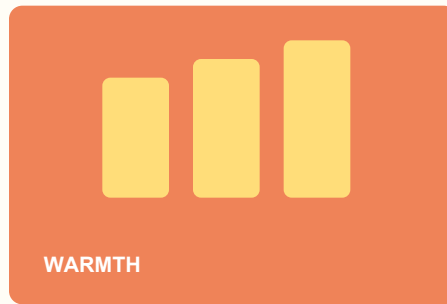
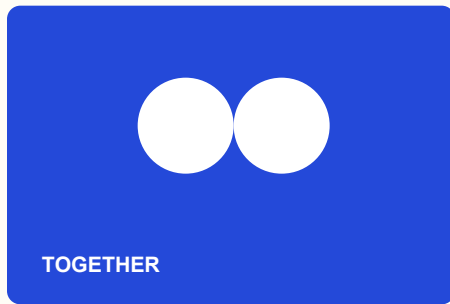
TEST IT / EXPLAIN YOUR EVIDENCE

Compare the close and broad views. Name information gained and information lost. Describe a two-shot sequence that would make the route clear.

NO PRESSURE. KEEP WHAT HELPS.

Make one deliberate choice.

Imagine a game where people need each other. Choose one feeling or piece of information you want the image to communicate.



TRY IT WITHOUT ANY SPECIAL SOFTWARE

Find one image, pause on a frame, or use the interactive studio. Say: "I want the viewer to notice _____. I will change _____ because _____." For course production, use a game engine (software for interactive games) or animation (images changing over time).

HELPER VOCABULARY / CONNECTING CHOICES

Moodboard

A curated collection of visual references that proposes the look, tone, and world of a project.

Palette

A selected group of colors and a plan for how they work together.

Visual cohesion

The sense that choices belong to the same world, even when they include intentional contrast.

Curation

Choosing and organizing references for a reason, rather than collecting everything you like.

THE MOODBOARD CONNECTION

These experiments can help you choose references and explain why they belong together. This recap creates no new assignment, grade, or deadline. Use the current course brief for assignment requirements.

NO PRESSURE. KEEP WHAT HELPS.

Let someone else surprise you.

Before you explain your intention, invite a viewer to tell you what they see. Their response is useful information, even when it differs from your prediction.

1 / SHOW

Let the image speak first.

2 / LISTEN

What did you notice first?

3 / REVISE

Choose one thing to test next.

WHEN YOU ARE NOT SURE WHAT TO SAY

Start with something visible: "I notice the bright doorway." Then offer a possibility: "It might be the destination." No need to guess the maker's intention.

HELPER VOCABULARY / CONNECTING CHOICES

Justification

Explaining why a choice belongs, with visible evidence and a connection to your intention.

Iteration

Making, testing, and revising a choice using what you learned.

Viewer test

Letting someone describe what they see before you explain what you intended.

Collaboration

People contributing to a shared effort and depending on one another. In this assignment it is also the subject of the imagined game.

A GOOD STOPPING POINT

You can stop after one observation. Save a screenshot or a short note if you want to remember it. Return when you are curious again.

YOU CAN PAUSE. YOU CAN SKIP.

Watch one thing. Notice one thing.

These links require internet. The explanations and illustrations in this PDF remain available offline. Choose a single clip if that is enough today.

Big Walk / House House / Panic

Watch up to 1:32. Pause on one frame. How do light, paths, and spacing help you find another person?

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vyQPc1i4Rpo>

Into the Spider-Verse / Sony Pictures Entertainment

Try 0:00-3:00 of the opening. You can stop sooner. Name what you notice first, then point to the feature that drew you there.

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=zzH4rV08TLI&t=0s>

Wilmot Works It Out / Hollow Ponds & Richard Hogg / Finji

Watch the short trailer, up to 2 minutes. How does arranging become something the player does, rather than something the player only looks at?

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=syfKNCYnz_s

IF YOU WOULD LIKE ANOTHER EXPLANATION

[Visual hierarchy / Envato Tuts+](#)

[Leading lines / Kellan Reck](#)

[Negative space / BBP Reel Insights](#)

[Establishing shots / StudioBinder](#)

[Rule of thirds / Learn Online Video](#)

[Depth of field / Never fStop](#)

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

CTIN 290 / Gordon Bellamy / Composition & Depth, September 9, 2026. Adapted from the course session plan and terms sheet. Original geometric illustrations and optional practice designed with AI assistance and prepared for instructor review. Helper vocabulary is included to support understanding, not to define an official assessment list.

"Blue Lock (visual)" is course shorthand, not a standard film term. Interpretations in examples are possibilities; a still image does not prove how every player will behave.

[Adobe / photo composition](#)

[StudioBinder / establishing shots](#)